

Bill 64 (2023)

Testimony

Planning and the Economy

MISC. COM. 298
P&E

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June 27, 2024

Honolulu City Council
530 South King Street Room 202
Honolulu, HI 96813

Subject: Testimony of Ryan D. Hurley, on behalf of self, RE: Bill 64 (2023), FD1,CD1
Related to Large wind energy generation facilities

Dear Chair, Kia'aina and fellow Council Members,

My name is Ryan Hurley. I am a community good government attorney who was formerly the wind and solar specialist for the Hawai'i State Energy Office and Commission Counsel at the Hawai'i Public Utilities Commission.

I support the 1.25-mile setback for large-scale wind turbines. This setback has been years in the making, driven by the Kahuku community. Despite over ten years of opposition and 200 arrests, the tallest land-based wind turbines were built less than 2,000 feet from their elementary and intermediate schools, as well as residences. Ironically, this project is now known as a poster child for energy equity failures and is considered one of the worst-cited renewable energy projects in America.

The 1.25-mile setback is essential for community safety. Developers and lobbyists like the Ulupono Initiative and HSEO argue that this setback will limit turbine placement, but this ignores the realities Hawaii's clean journey, which we now know will need to be supplemented by "firm" biofuels because our energy grid has become increasingly intermittent. The governor's recent plan to examine LNG, while environmentally dangerous, raises further questions about the need to place turbines so dangerously close to our unique communities.

Additionally, the idea of adding longer blades as part of maintenance raises several issues. Wind turbine blades are not "plug and play," and you can't just buy aftermarket blades for different turbines. Existing turbines would need new blades, nacelles, and gearboxes, especially since some manufacturers have gone out of business. Adjusting tower heights could be done using the same foundations. Developers could add smaller or similarly sized blades instead of larger ones. The idea that only larger blades are available is a fallacy that benefits developers and harms the community.

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Adding longer blades would increase the swept area of the turbines. As the Na Pua Makani project's EIS states, "larger rotor swept areas could influence collision risk." Increasing blade length would likely increase bird and bat fatalities, creating unassessed impacts. Allowing these impacts without proper assessment would violate public trust duties and invite lawsuits related to insufficient environmental assessments, exacerbating harm to the community.

In conclusion, please keep the 1.25-mile setback and do not allow any extensions to blade length on existing projects or grandfathering existing project turbines.

Kindly,

Ryan Hurley